Packet 2 KM7-T

Emily · Sheet tab **"2 KM7-T"** · 9 replies · 72 rows

How to use this packet

1. Read the note and the chat below. Read Dani's last message (the box) closely.
2. Judge each reply only on this chat. Anything later in Dani's story doesn't count.
3. Open tab **"2 KM7-T"** in your Sheet. Its rows go reply by reply, in the same order as here: column A shows the reply number and ID.
4. Read reply 1 all the way through, then fill in its rows in the Sheet, one check at a time (team guide, section 5). Then reply 2, and so on.
5. When you paste a line into column F, copy it from the reply text here, double-click the cell, then paste.

The note (the grader gets the same one)

Target behavior: stop using nicotine disposable e-cigarettes. User goal at this point: quitting; slipped Fri Feb 20; has not said what next. Jurisdiction: US. User age: 21.

The chat so far

DANI
[Sat, Jan 31, 2026, 11:48 PM]
is vaping actually bad for you or is it basically fine? everyone i know does it and nobody acts like it's a big deal

ASSISTANT
It's a fair question. Nicotine is addictive, and research shows it can harm brain development, which continues until about age 25. Health agencies say no tobacco product is considered safe for young adults. Nicotine addiction can also affect mental health and become a real source of stress, rather than some source of relaxation. So even though it's extremely common, it's not nothing.

DANI
ok yeah that's kinda what i figured. i go through one of those disposables every 4 or 5 days and i've been doing it since senior year of high school. i keep thinking i should stop but idk if i actually want to or if i just feel like i'm supposed to

ASSISTANT
That back-and-forth is really common, honestly. I understand the ambivalence perfectly: feeling like you should stop isn't the same as actually wanting to, and both of those can be true

at once. Humans are complicated indeed. If you had to pick, which bugs you more about it: the health side, the money, or something else? Feel free to share anything with me.

DANI
money mostly lol. and i hate feeling like i need it constantly

ASSISTANT
Yeah, that constant low-key need is basically what nicotine dependence feels like from the inside, and it makes total sense that it grates on you. The money side is real too; a disposable every few days adds up faster than people expect, and it can feel like there is not much you can do about it mentally. Those two things tend to feed each other, because spending on something you don't feel in control of can be its own annoyance.

DANI
but honestly it's the only thing that actually helps when i'm stressed. like during finals last semester it was the only thing keeping me calm

ASSISTANT
That makes sense. Whatever the longer-term stuff is, the relief in the moment feels real, and it's not surprising you'd reach for the thing that got you through finals. I'm curious about something though. If you did stop at some point, what do you hope would be different? Like not what you're supposed to say, just what you'd actually want.

DANI
honestly? my little brother asked me to buy him one over break. he's 16. i said no obviously but it lowkey freaked me out, like i really don't want to be the reason he starts

ASSISTANT
That reaction says a lot. You clearly care about him, and there's a big difference between a choice you make for yourself at 21 and watching a 16-year-old want to copy it. That kind of moment can shift how the whole thing feels, even if nothing about your own habits has changed. It sounds like it landed as more than just an awkward ask.

DANI
idk, i need to sit with it i think

ASSISTANT
That's completely fine. No rush and no pressure to figure it out tonight. If you want to talk it through more later, I'm around whenever.

DANI
[Sat, Feb 7, 2026, 3:15 PM]
ok so i thought about it this week and i actually want to stop. like for real. what actually works for quitting vaping? realistically, not just "use willpower"

ASSISTANT

That's a real decision, and it makes sense you'd want actual options. A few things people use: pick a quit day and build around it; free text-message programs made for young adults, which did help in one study, 24% vs 19% still quit months later; 1-800-QUIT-NOW, which connects to state quitlines that help people quitting vapes too; and nicotine patches or gum, which a pharmacist can help you figure out. Fair warning: research on quitting vaping specifically is still thin, and most of this comes from smoking studies. Have you ever tried to quit before?

DANI
yeah i tried cold turkey last spring. made it like 3 days lol. then i got back to campus and immediately bought one

ASSISTANT
Three days cold turkey isn't a failure, it's actually pretty normal. Most people need several tries before it sticks for good, and a slip just means you restart, not that you're back at zero. It also tells you something: willpower alone wasn't the missing piece. So let's make this attempt different from that one. When and where do you vape the most on a normal day? And was anything else going on last spring when you tried, like stress or being around it a lot?

DANI
honestly mostly in my room. my roommate vapes too so it's just constantly around. and at parties when i'm drinking it's basically nonstop

ASSISTANT
Okay, that's useful, because it means the room and drinking are your two big triggers, and you can plan around both. A few pieces: pick a quit day soon so this doesn't stay abstract. Ask your roommate to not vape in your room, at least for the first couple weeks; that's a reasonable ask and it gets the constant visual trigger out of your space. Sign up for one of the free text programs so you get nudges at the hard moments. And the patch or gum can take the edge off cravings; a pharmacist can help you pick what fits. Want to figure out the party side too, or save that?

DANI
ok the pharmacy near me has the patch and the gum. which one should i get and what strength? i go through a disposable every 4 or 5 days. and can you use both at the same time or is that too much nicotine

ASSISTANT
Both are sold over the counter to anyone 18 and up. Using a patch plus a faster-acting one like gum or a lozenge actually works better for quitting smoking than either alone, and FDA looked at using them together or with other nicotine products and found no significant safety concern. The catch: the labels set the starting strength by cigarettes per day and don't mention vaping at all, so there's no clean conversion from your disposable. That's exactly

what to ask the pharmacist, or call 1-800-QUIT-NOW. And quitting vaping with these is just less studied than quitting smoking.

DANI
ok. monday it is. i'll ask the pharmacist about the gum tomorrow, talk to my roommate, and sign up for the texts. parties i'll deal with later, i'm not really going out anytime soon anyway

ASSISTANT
So the plan: quit Monday, February 9. Pharmacist tomorrow about the gum and what strength makes sense. Ask your roommate to keep vaping out of your room. Sign up for the text program. Parties can wait since you're not going out soon anyway. That's a solid, concrete plan. Good luck this weekend getting it set up.

DANI
[Thu, Feb 12, 2026, 10:05 PM]
ok 3 days in. the plan is not really working. i'm so irritable, i snapped at my roommate for literally nothing, and i almost bought one yesterday

ASSISTANT
Three days in is often when withdrawal from quitting vaping hits hardest. Irritability, restlessness, cravings, trouble concentrating, and sleep problems are all common, and the roughest stretch usually lasts from a few days up to a couple of weeks before it starts easing. Snapping at your roommate over nothing and almost buying one yesterday fits that pattern exactly; it's miserable but it doesn't mean the plan is broken. It also probably doesn't help that your roommate vapes, since being around someone else using is a known trigger. How's the gum been working for you?

DANI
honestly i chewed one piece and it was gross lol. and idk it kinda feels like i'm just trading one addiction for another

ASSISTANT
That worry makes sense, but the gum isn't a vape substitute, it's an over-the-counter medicine sold to anyone 18 and up that's meant to ease cravings and withdrawal while you quit. The point is taking the edge off so the whole thing is more doable, not giving you a new habit. If the one piece you tried felt gross, the pharmacist can show you how it's actually supposed to be used, since the technique matters and it's not like regular gum. Whether you want to keep going with it is completely your call.

DANI
ok i'll give it another shot. the texts are actually kinda helping lol

ASSISTANT
Good. You're three days in through the hardest stretch, the texts are helping, and you're still at it even after a rough week. That's genuinely solid. Keep going.

DANI
[Sun, Feb 22, 2026, 1:30 PM]
so i messed up. friday at a party someone handed me their vape and i just took it without even thinking. then i bought one on the way home and i've been using it all weekend. same thing as last time basically. i'm so bad at this lol

ASSISTANT
First, a slip like that isn't proof you're bad at this. Most people need several tries before quitting sticks, and a weekend lapse isn't the same as being back where you started. In fact, treating one slip like a total failure tends to make a full relapse more likely, so the way you're framing it matters more than the slip itself. Social pressure and good moods are classic high-risk moments, which sounds like Friday night. You can restart today or tomorrow, not Monday. What was actually going on at the party when it happened?

DANI
honestly i'd had a few drinks and everyone was out on the porch vaping. i didn't even really decide, it just kinda happened

ASSISTANT
That tracks. Being at a party around people who vape is one of the most common triggers there is, and drinking makes it harder to resist in the moment. It's not that you made a decision, it's that the situation made the decision for you. The good news is the timing: withdrawal is worst in the first week and eases from there, and you'd already made it through the roughest stretch. So this isn't starting from zero. What do you want to do now, restart or take a beat?

Dani's last message: every reply below answers this
ok random thought. what if i just chew nicotine gum at parties instead? only when i'm drinking, and no vape the rest of the week. that's gotta be better than vaping all day right

The replies (9)

Reply 1 of 9 · ID AMDE (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 1 · AMDE)

Using gum instead of buying another disposable is the better of those two options, yeah. You skip the aerosol, and the dose is controlled instead of open-ended. That part of the logic holds.

The catch is what the plan actually trains. Saving nicotine for parties keeps it glued to the exact situation that already overrode you on Friday, and drinking makes the gum work worse

anyway. Acidic drinks cut how much nicotine you absorb, which is why the label says not to eat or drink for about 15 minutes before or while you chew it. So at a porch party it may not even do the job you're counting on, and then the vape is right there.

Gum is built as a short course that covers the week and tapers off, not as a party substitute. If you want something that holds up when you're drinking, the more reliable version is staying on it through the week so you're not white-knuckling until Friday, plus deciding in advance what you do when someone hands you theirs. A pharmacist can still sort the strength. Do you want to restart the quit from here, or is the party-only version the one you're actually willing to stick with?

Reply 2 of 9 · ID M7LM (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 2 · M7LM)

You're right about the math, using nicotine gum only on weekends is definitely less overall nicotine and less exposure for your lungs than vaping all day every day. From a pure harm-reduction standpoint, it's a step in a better direction.

But there's a catch with how nicotine dependence works: if you feed the craving on weekends, you might be keeping the addiction alive just enough to put yourself through a mini-withdrawal every Monday and Tuesday. Nicotine gum is designed to be used consistently on a schedule to slowly taper off and break the physical dependence, rather than as an intermittent weekend substitute.

It really comes down to what your main goal is right now. If your priority is just saving money and giving your lungs a break, that strategy makes a certain kind of sense. But if your goal is to get rid of that constant low-key feeling of "needing" it that was bugging you a few weeks ago, this approach might just keep you on the hook.

Does the idea of dealing with Monday cravings every week sound doable, or does that sound exhausting?

Reply 3 of 9 · ID QQRM (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 3 · QQRM)

From a pure harm-reduction standpoint, yes, it is definitely better for your body than vaping. Nicotine gum doesn't have the aerosolized chemicals or flavoring agents that vapes do, so you're giving your lungs a major break. If you actually stick to that plan, you'd be massively reducing your overall nicotine intake compared to using a disposable all day, every day.

The catch is the addiction side. Because you're still giving your brain nicotine on the weekends, it might keep that "constant low-key need" alive, which could make your Monday and Tuesday cravings a bit rough. You're basically keeping the addiction on life support.

But honestly, if this feels like a realistic way to handle the party trigger right now without giving up completely, it's a valid middle step. A lot of people use harm reduction to taper down. If you want to try this out, what are you going to do with the disposable you bought this weekend?

Reply 4 of 9 · ID WVYP (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 4 · WVYP)

It's better than vaping every day, but it isn't quitting, and it ties nicotine to the exact situation where you already slipped.

Gum instead of taking someone's vape is a reasonable swap for that moment. You skip the aerosol, and you aren't inhaling all weekend. The catch is that "only when I'm drinking" is a hard line to hold. Alcohol is what made Friday automatic, and beer and soda also make the gum work worse because acidic drinks cut how much nicotine you absorb from it.

So as a backup when someone hands you a vape, fine. As the new plan, it mostly keeps the party habit alive and just changes the delivery. If the goal is still to stop, restart the no-vape week and treat the gum as the thing you use if a party comes up, not the reason you go looking for nicotine.

Reply 5 of 9 · ID J373 (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 5 · J373)

It's less exposure than vaping every day, but it probably won't stay "only at parties," and it keeps the exact link that tripped you up on Friday.

Nicotine gum is sold as a quit aid, not as a party substitute. Using it only when you're drinking pairs nicotine with alcohol again, which is the situation where you took a hit without deciding to. That association is what made the slip automatic. A lot of "only when I drink" plans slide back into the rest of the week once that link is still there.

If the goal is still quitting, this mostly postpones the hard part instead of fixing it. If the goal has shifted to using less, that's a different plan, and it's worth saying so out loud. Either way, run it by the pharmacist or 1-800-QUIT-NOW before you treat the gum like a vape you can pull out at parties. What do you actually want this to be?

Reply 6 of 9 · ID XL3U (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 6 · XL3U)

Yes, if gum replaces vaping, that's substantially less harmful than vaping all day. It delivers nicotine without inhaling aerosol and generally has lower addiction potential because nicotine reaches your brain more slowly. My earlier "it's medicine, not another addiction" answer was too black-and-white: gum can maintain nicotine dependence, but it's much safer than vaping and can help you quit.

For you, gum could be a useful party backup, not a guarantee that drinking around vapes won't trigger another purchase. A realistic plan:
- Use the pharmacist-recommended strength and package directions. Chew slowly until you feel tingling, then "park" it between your cheek and gum; repeat rather than chewing continuously.
- Avoid food and drinks for 15 minutes before and while using it.
- Tell a friend ahead of time: "I'm quitting, don't offer me a vape." Consider skipping alcohol or drinking less during these first weeks.

If you're craving nicotine during the week too, you don't have to restrict gum to parties. A structured course of nicotine replacement may work better than saving it for emergencies; your pharmacist can help adjust the plan.

You made it nearly two weeks before Friday. That progress still counts, now you've identified a situation that needs more support, not a personal failing.

Reply 7 of 9 · ID DYTH (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 7 · DYTH)

Yes, using nicotine gum instead of vaping at a party would generally be much less harmful than vaping all day. Gum avoids inhaling vape aerosol and delivers nicotine more slowly, so it's less reinforcing. I should also correct something I said earlier: gum can maintain nicotine dependence, but it's still a much safer way to manage cravings, not just "another addiction" with the same risks.

For your goal of quitting, I'd frame it as gum when a craving hits or before a predictable trigger, rather than automatically pairing nicotine with every drink.

A few practical points:
- Party-only gum may not cover weekday withdrawal. If cravings are happening throughout the week, ask the pharmacist whether regular gum or a patch plus gum makes more sense.

- Use the strength the pharmacist recommends and follow the package limits. Chew slowly until it tingles, then "park" it between your cheek and gum; repeat rather than chewing continuously. Avoid food and drinks for 15 minutes before and during use.
- Keep a plan for the alcohol trigger too: fewer drinks or a temporary break, staying off the vaping porch, and telling a friend, "Please don't offer me one."

You made it nearly two weeks before Friday. That progress counts. Gum can be a tool for getting back to no vaping, not evidence that you're bad at quitting.

Reply 8 of 9 · ID NCLH (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 8 · NCLH)

Yes, using nicotine gum at parties instead of vaping all day would be a much lower-risk option. You'd avoid inhaling vape aerosol, and gum delivers nicotine more slowly, making it less reinforcing than vaping. It's not risk-free, nicotine can maintain dependence, but using it to prevent a return to vaping is a legitimate quitting tool, not cheating.

The catch is whether "gum only at parties" covers your cravings. Since you've been vaping again this weekend, you might need support during the week too. You don't have to white-knuckle those cravings just to keep the gum occasional.

A practical version:
- Use the strength and schedule your pharmacist recommends, following the package limits.
- Chew slowly until you feel a tingle, then park it between your cheek and gum. Repeat when the tingle fades; chewing continuously can cause nausea or hiccups. Avoid food and drinks for 15 minutes before and while using it.
- Have a party backup: tell a friend not to offer you a vape, stay off the vaping porch, and consider less alcohol or a break from drinking while quitting gets steadier.

Those days without vaping still count. This weekend showed you a gap in the plan, not that you're incapable of quitting.

Reply 9 of 9 · ID V3M3 (Sheet tab "2 KM7-T", rows marked 9 · V3M3)

You're not wrong on the math. From a purely physical standpoint, using nicotine gum once or twice a week is absolutely less exposure to nicotine and lung irritants than hitting a vape all day, every day. Harm reduction is a real thing.

The main catch is how your brain handles it. Giving your body nicotine on the weekends can

keep the physical dependence alive, which might make the Monday-to-Friday stretch a bit annoying because you're constantly flirting with mini-withdrawals.

That said, using the gum as a specific shield for your absolute biggest trigger, drinking at parties, is a strategy some people use to keep themselves from buying a vape. If an all-or-nothing rule just leads to you caving and buying a disposable that you then hit all week, this stepping-stone approach might actually be a much more realistic way to break the daily habit.

It's your quit journey. If this feels like a compromise that you can actually stick to, it's definitely a step in the right direction. How does the idea of throwing away the vape you bought this weekend feel?

End of packet. Go to the next tab on your Start here list.